IT WAS NEVER JUST HUNGER

ONE MOTHER'S FIGHT, A COMMUNITY'S BREAKTHROUGH, AND A FUTURE THAT'S BEEN IMPOSSIBLE TO IMAGINE...

By Kate Fletcher

Hunger, for most people, is a fleeting discomfort.

It passes...
It waits...
It speaks politely and then quiets once it's been fed.

But in the world of Prader-Willi Syndrome (PWS), hunger is something else entirely.

It is not a whisper but a scream—unrelenting, unsatisfied, and unyielding.
A demand written into the brain's deepest wiring.

And for the people living with it, and the families trying to help them survive it, hunger becomes a shadow that touches everything.

But PWS isn't just about hunger.

Not really.
It's about what happens when your child's biology betrays them—and nothing you do as a parent can make it stop. It's about sleepless nights and explosive days.

About rage that has no target.

About joy that's often held hostage by survival.

It's about a kind of invisible grief: the loss of a life that might have been, and the fierce, complicated love for the one unfolding in its place.

For more decades, there has been no real treatment.

Families have been left to manage a disorder so rare and misunderstood that most doctors couldn't explain it, much less help. Support systems were cobbled together from Facebook threads and trial-and-error. Medical journals said it was hopeless.

Most people had never heard of it.

And then, this March of 2025, something extraordinary happened.

The U.S. Food and Drug Administration finally approved DCCR—*diazoxide choline extended-release*—the first medication specifically developed to treat hyperphagia in PWS.

It was a milestone carved out not just by science, but by families who refused to be invisible: who documented every meltdown, who drove across state lines for trial appointments, who testified, emailed, begged, and wept.

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Author Joe Due